Mark Waugh and Graeme Swann spring to mind, but there aren't that many natural slippers, who have an innate sense of movement to get into the right position for the catch. It looks easy, but you must work at it. The ball is coming at 90 mph, and you might not have had a sniff all day. The natural thing is to snatch at it.

The ball does hurt, incidentally, especially when it hits the end of your fingers on a cold day. April cricket in England can be horrendous; it explains why our catching techniques are worse than those of the Australians or South Africans, who field in warmer conditions, where the sting is not so painful. It is no surprise we are starting to integrate catching gloves into training.

In simple terms, your hands have to be relaxed, yet firm. You need to move your body, keep your weight forward and align your eyes to the line of the ball. Our eye-testing programme at Loughborough confirmed I had very good lower vision, but I struggled getting to the ball low to my left because of a basic lack of flexibility.

I was a pretty efficient catcher when the ball came to me at shoulder height but dropped more than I should in the bread basket. Though I struggled with some of those easier chances, I forced myself to improve through repetition. I would take literally thousands of catches, from machines, off the face of a bat or off a trampoline net. I fielded at gully, short leg and mid-on with England before settling on slip because I felt, as captain, I could exert greater influence standing there.

So much for the theory. The outcome, on that particular morning in Nottingham, was that I took three slip catches, to remove Ashton Agar, Mitchell Starc and Peter Siddle. They were all off the bowling of Jimmy Anderson, whose unbroken thirteen-over spell was only curtailed by cramp. Natural talent, you see, is never enough.

Jimmy's willingness to sacrifice himself is as fundamental to him as the accuracy of his orthodox and reverse swing, cutters and slower balls. It gave us insurance against the defiance of Australia's final pair of Brad Haddin and James Pattinson, who took them to within twenty runs of victory at a delayed lunch interval.

That was where the raw cunning kicked in. Jimmy, as the senior bowler, demanded to know who was going to bowl on the resumption. I deliberately said nothing, and smiled, knowing the message would get through. Jimmy